



DR Congo Cobalt Mining

And its Pollution and Ecological Destruction

Preston Gonzalez

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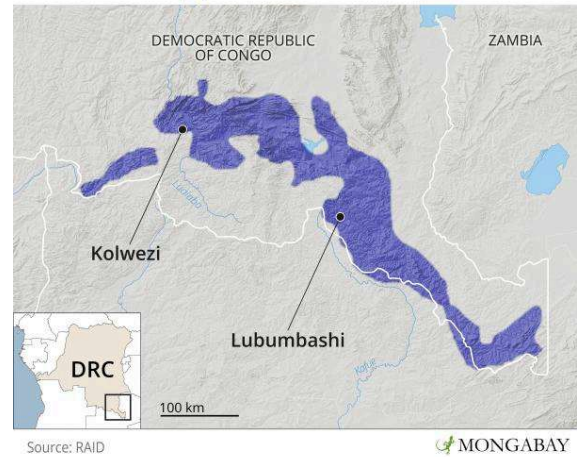
DR Congo Cobalt Mining Pollution

Cobalt Mining in the Democratic Republic of the Congo: The Sacrifice to Fuel Progress

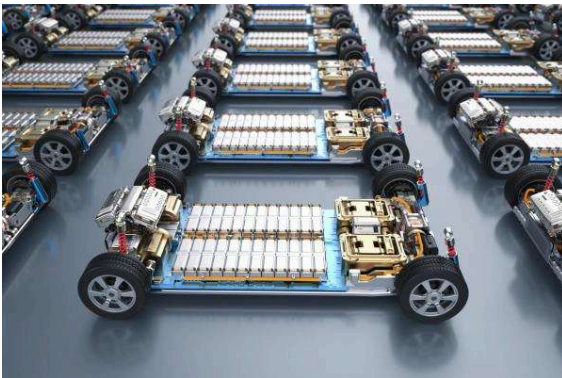
As the world looks for solutions to climate change, battery operated systems got popularized and marketed as emission

free clean energy. This, however, is a lie. Lithium Ion batteries, the heart of many battery powered systems, rely on cobalt, an ore that comprises $\frac{1}{3}$ of the battery itself. The Democratic Republic of Congo mines the majority of the world's cobalt and they are being used to fuel the generation of battery operated systems for “clean energy. Yet as we explore down below, cobalt mining, a core component of lithium Ion batteries, is far from emission free. The rising demand for cobalt and the growth of technology puts stress on the Dominican Republic of Congo to meet these needs no matter what. We'll explore how cobalt mining led to huge environmental damage, social change, and slavery.

Copper-Cobalt Belt



The Explosion in Demand



EV Car's Large Battery Frame

Cobalt demand tripled only within the past decade. The rapid growth of EV, iPhones, car batteries, and a lot more all rely on cobalt therefore increasing its demand indirectly. The DRC has 19 different mines and the largest being the Kamoto mine that produces roughly 27,000 tons of cobalt a year.

Two types of miners extract cobalt in the DRC; industrial mines and artisanal mines. Industrial miners work high paying and safer jobs while relying on a company. Artisanal miners work in unregulated and dangerous environments. Sadly, a decent amount of artisanal miners are working. Doing this, the DRC is able to hide the mistreatment of their workers and environmental costs sacrificed to mine cobalt.

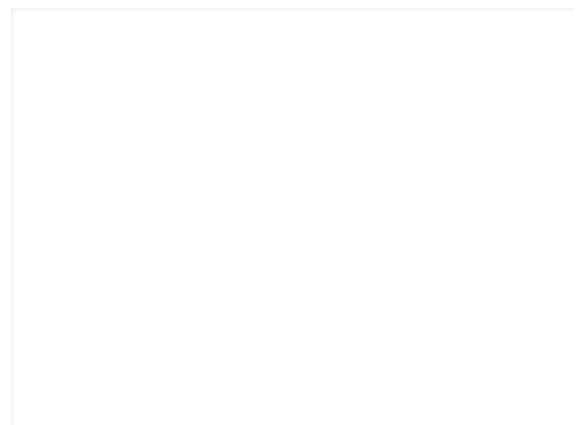
Environmental Impacts



In terms of environmental impact, cobalt mines release 291,000 tons of CO₂ each year. This significant amount of greenhouse gasses along with other pollutants affect the wildlife, forests, and especially water sources. The water runoff of cobalt mines infect lakes, rivers, streams, and the soil causing eutrophication. Eutrophication is overflowing bodies of water with too much nutrients which kills and infects aquatic life. Not just cobalt is mined either. Oftentimes there is copper, uranium, and lead. These heavy metals and radioactive material also leak outside the mines and seep into water sources, wildlife, and damaging the environment. Not often are safety precautions practiced in artisanal miners leading to increased risk to both the miners and the environment. Mining also creates a lot of air pollution from mineral dust, and dirt getting picked up into the wind and moving somewhere else.

Human Consequence

As said previously, there is great risk involved with cobalt mining. Artisanal miners put their health at risk in order for a foreign company to get rich and turn cobalt into a finished product. These artisanal miners pay the price for the 'worlds' success. Dust breathed in can cause cancer,



Cobalt Mine Water Pollution Run-off

respiratory issues, and impairing brain function. Mines also attract an unwanted crowd of illegal activity. Things like sex trafficking, slavery, child labor are common and not acted upon since all the funding goes towards the mining.



On the other hand, industrial mining brings some employment and can lead to the development of a middle class for the local population, but the greater financial reward lies with the foreign corporations—a common effect of neoliberal policies. On the other hand, the communities that surround the mines bear the cost of poor health, environmental degradation, and all the negative consequences, while the international community gets to reap

Cobalt Mining Slave holds Blue Cobalt Ore

the rewards of cobalt-enhanced technology. When the foreign firms disregard the rights of the miners, this further cements the attitude that financial reward is of greater importance than people. This is especially true in that it widens social divides within the DR Congo, establishing a master-and-servant relationship.

Conclusion

Still, there are lots of industrial mining jobs open for people who are looking for a stable good paying job in accordance with Dominican Republic of Congo's standards. But the upsides cannot pull you away from the damage cobalt mining has done to the DRC. Plus, they don't even get most of the money. Foreign companies buy out and supply the market which is a form of neoliberalism. These companies failures to recognize human needs and rights as well as environmental rules creates an imbalance allowing for harm and pollution to seep into DRC. They sacrificed their country, environment, people, and a lot more just so we could get our batteries.

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